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Victor Rendón

Latin percussionist and music educator Victor Rendón is a veteran of the New York City Latin jazz scene. He teaches at Lehman College in the Bronx, and is the leader of the Bronx Conexion Latin-Jazz Big Band.

Victor was interviewed in Clinton, New York on November 15, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe over at the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very happy to have percussionist Victor Rendón with me. How'd I do?

VR: That's great, beautiful.

MR: I was just overwhelmed with the amount of information yesterday from the clinic you did.

VR: I could tell. I was watching you. You caught my eye.

MR: Yeah. That percussive music just seems to, it's like a magnet. It draws you in and it's mystifying to me but it's wonderful.

VR: Yes, yes. And all your questions make a lot of sense because all those questions are questions that I ask myself as I was learning, and still learning. You know it's an endless lifetime study you know, all this percussion, you know Afro-Caribbean percussion. It's just one after another. And there's a lot of stuff that hasn't been discovered yet, you know, by the general public you know, in South America in particular.

MR: I was wondering about that, when Cascadú was talking about specific rhythms that are related to specific deities. And where those connections came from, how far back did it go and is it possible to know why this rhythm connected with this spiritual being?

VR: That's a good question because the music, the batá music that we played for you yesterday, it's — the origins is from Nigeria, Yorubaland. And if you listen to, I've listened to the batá drumming that's still in existence there and a lot of it doesn't sound like what has evolved in Cuba and the rest of the, like in the United States. I recognized a few things like Ochosi and also they have like four drums instead of three. We're playing on three. And one of the guys, I'm not sure which one because I don't know that much to be honest with you, but the African batá drumming, but he's playing two. So it has evolved. Now how the rhythms, you were asking about the rhythms, I recognize one or two and the others were totally different. So it's something that developed here in the New World I would think. The batá drumming from what I've read came around early — I don't want to say a year because I'm not sure, around early 1800s from a pair of slaves that were in Cuba and it evolved from there. But I can not say specifically why the rhythms developed the way they are. I wish — that's a good research.

MR: Yes it is someone's Ph.D. for sure.

VR: Yes or a good doctoral dissertation.

MR: Yes indeed. There was a great moment yesterday. Someone asked a question about how much of what you're doing is improvised. And I believe the answer was, "Well some but most of this is fairly specific."

VR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: So then the three of you played one of your rhythms and it was going on for a while and there was a moment where you flashed this big smile. Something happened and you just had this great smile and you were looking at the other two fellas. And I wondered, at the time, what just happened?

VR: I think I know that moment. I slapped my left side. I was playing to Elegua if this is what — and it was an inflection coming from me. It was not necessarily something that had to be done. So I was playing this rhythm [scats] that's basic. Like I was talking about the language, just learn the basic [scats]. And Cascadú responded by sort of laughing or smiling at me, and I think I looked at him and we had that little moment. I think that's what you're talking about, yes.

MR: I love that. I mean it happens in jazz a lot too when someone plays something and sometimes the response doesn't necessarily have to be an exact copy. "Oh you're playing that, I can play that too." Because that can get obnoxious after a while if it goes on for too long. But that communication, that interaction.

VR: Yes, yes. And again, the lady who asked whether it's improvised or set, and I said, "Yes they are set but you can have variations within that language. Like right now we're talking. I speak with a Spanish accent, you speak with your background accent, but it's still the same language. You know we can have different inflections. It's still the basic language is still there. You can move it around a little bit. You say toMato, I say tomate, you go outside it's tomAto. It's still the same language. We understand it.

MR: How do you teach what seems to be very complex rhythms and many rhythms. Where do you start with a novice?

VR: Very good question. In Cuba it's by rote. It's an oral tradition and, I've been there, and what they do, and I've seen it happen here in the United States in New York City, the novice would basically sit there or maybe stand against the wall and just listen. They just pick it up by ear. And back in the old days they would do that for a couple of years or so, and if you were not an annoyance they would let you stay there and then maybe they would let you play and, like at a ceremony a lot of times the teacher will go to the beginner and he will play the drum this way so that he can follow him, or he will get behind him and tap you from your shoulder. I learned differently because being a percussionist that can read music I looked at transcriptions where I transcribed it myself

so I will actually write things out and then I'll memorize it. But I find that looking at the paper reading it, it's not the same because the sooner you can play it by memory then it becomes a part of you. Because for many years, like what you saw yesterday, I will read it like the newspaper. But it wasn't until I put the papers away that I started to feel it spiritually within myself.

MR: Would notated music for the batá have two staves? Would it be — because you're playing two —

VR: Yes, because the way I write it, there's no standardized way. I write the left hand, I think — treble clef, I write the left hand on the E, the fifth space. And I write the right hand on the F space.

MR: I'm thinking now, the right hand plays the lower tone, right?

VR: Yes, yes, yes, yes. So A – E – A – E — F – E — F – E. And if I have like a muffled tone I'll put it on the G space. But that's my notation. It's not necessarily standardized. Oh going back to the teaching, I do have a group of students coming in on Sundays and I'm teaching them by rote pretty much, even the ones that can read music. Once in a while I'll take out a sheet of paper and I'll show them, this is what it looks like. But for the most part my emphasis is that if you come in every week you'll get it. You cannot go backwards, you can only go forwards you know.

MR: Okay. It reminds me of one of our professors here has a gamelan orchestra. And she teaches students to play that music and — no music involved, no written music. They're learning their parts by ear and muscle memory I guess, which is the way, a really good way to learn music I think.

VR: Yes. I found that after a while I was always afraid, the iya drum, the bigger drum, it's the one that calls you. And I found out that after a while my hands would just respond to what was being called. Almost like ooh, I remembered, but it was just my hands remembering what to do. You mentioned the muscle memory. It just sort of kicks in after a while. And we also have certain sounds to represent the right hand, like on the smaller drum key-la — key-la "key" is my right hand and "la" is my left hand. So what's a word for that type of thing. Phonetically?

MR: Phonetically, well that'll do.

VR: But you know what I mean, the syllables, like in Indian drumming they represent certain sounds.

MR: That's right with the tabla.

VR: Yes, yes. So I use that a lot key-la, key-la. Klin is playing with both hands at the same — klin-klin-ke-la, Klin-ke-la, Klin-ke-la, Klin-ke-la. I just did ergun and that's the way I teach. That's the standard way to teach it. Yes.

MR: It seems — I think I told you yesterday that most musicians in this country can get through a lifetime of gigs and their Latin repertoire consists of "Girl from Ipanema."

VR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: And maybe one other tune. But when you're playing for dancers who know what they're doing that's — tempos seem extremely important. What distinguishes a mambo from a cha cha?

VR: Yes. It took me a long time to internalize that. Because we have terms like mambo. We have cha cha cha. We have son son montuno. Guaracha. What is all this? And a lot of it is the same rhythm but at a slower tempo. Like a mambo might be here [scats]. But then if you slow it down [scats] then it becomes a son montuno. It just feels differently. Again the word mambo is used very loosely. Tito Puente had his mambos, like what we were doing during rehearsal yesterday. But then Perez Prado [scats], that was a mambo too, which is more like a cha cha. But then he had the piano [scats]. He didn't have that. It felt more like in two. So it takes a long time to learn what it is.

MR: You said something about these terms get confusing over the years and you mentioned the rumba.

VR: Yes, yes.

MR: And I had a great example of that when one of these dance instructors that we play for said, "You guys need to learn more cha chas like 'Billy Jean.'" I said, "Michael Jackson's 'Billy Jean'?" She said, "yes, a cha cha like that." So she's calling that song a cha cha.

VR: Uh huh. I can see why because [scats] you can superimpose the cha cha over it. So I know where he's coming from.

MR: All right.

VR: The same tempo, yes exactly.

MR: I'm going to take a lesson from that. Because sometimes you're like, oh, how do I nail this cha cha rhythm and tempo especially.

VR: And the rumba, there was a label R – H – U – M – B - A that was confusing for me in my younger days because here I am learning rumba — R – U – M – B – A, the traditional folkloric way, then you have the rumbas of Xavier Cugat, you know and all that, from back in the 30s, 40s and 50s. And I kind of realized it was just a term, a label that they put on the music. And like where I come from it was mostly musica tropical, you know, tropical music. And later on in the 60s the term salsa came into the scene and now it's called salsa. So it's like a blanket generic term for the music. But it's not necessarily a rhythm you know.

MR: The rhythms that really got my heart going yesterday were those 6/8 things. And I think it's such a powerful feeling because you can feel it in two, you can feel it in six, and you can move your body in different ways to it.

VR: Like we did "Rumba Colombia" [scats] 1-2-3-4-5-6; 1-2-3- 4-5-6. But then the quinto player is going [scats]. It's like a different improvisation, it's in two, it's just in duple feel against the 6/8. And also we have the clave [scats] I can do the other part instead of doing this [scats]. That's in two. So you have all this interplay and it's really interesting. And again, it took me a long time to really understand it, because my mind wouldn't accept it, being a schooled musician.

MR: No, you don't learn this overnight. Ai yi yi. And you spent some time as a bandleader. What was that experience like?

VR: Yeah, well I'm still a bandleader. We're playing today as a matter of fact. But you had Rodriguez/Rendón Latin Jazz Orchestra.

MR: That was my first band in New York City. I think we formed it in 1990. We formed the band because we were playing at this other — and I won't say the name because I won't insult — we were playing with this older gentleman. And he had this concept of having a small big band. But he was so disorganized, and the music wasn't quite there, and then you have 15 people and he would go around and let everybody take a solo, which can be a real drag after 40 minutes or so. Then we said, me and Arman said we can do better than this. Plus we can write our own arrangements. So we formed the Armando Rodriguez/Victor Rendón Jazz Orchestra — a real mouthful, right. And we recorded our first album in 1992, it came out in 1993. "Juarez" I don't know if you have that, which I'll get to you. Then we did our second CD, it came out in 1998 and that's a very nice CD "Havana Blues" — have you seen that one?

MR: No.

VR: Okay, I'll have to get it to you. Chico O'Farrill wrote four of the arrangements for that. It was two big band sessions — one big band with two tunes, and then a smaller group, four horn things that he did with us. And I wrote a couple of things and Armando did the same. That's a very nice album, "Havana Blues." And that was it for that band. We're still friends but we parted our ways. We teach now, together.

MR: What are some of the things you learned as being a bandleader?

VR: As a bandleader you have to be very well organized — with a big band now in particular I mean just putting the music in order sometimes. I go through — you know every time we have a gig I don't depend on the musicians to do it for me you know because you call it out and then oh I can't find it. A paper gets lost or something, or it gets detached.

MR: Misfiled. Yes.

VR: It's a nightmare. So I go through the books. It might take me anywhere from an hour to two hours just to make sure that the books are set. So I have to know, I have to follow the music. I have at least 80 arrangements in the book right now but I can't carry all the music with me so I have to decide what to play on a monthly basis.

MR: Before you leave home.

VR: Yes. So that I don't have to carry everything. I have to make sure that I communicate and make it known what I expect from my band members. Like today for example I sent out an email to please meet the bus at 10 AM. We leave at 10:30, not 11, not 11:30 you know, in a nice way but in a business type of way. And if you do it consistently they get the message, so that's very important. So organization I think is one of the main things. And if you've got good musicians the music will take care of itself, I'm not worried about that. That's the easy part.

MR: Indeed. What do you do if, I mean you're trying to gather 15, 16 musicians or more on a particular date. Do you have subs if you need to?

VR: Yes we have a pool of subs. Again I depend on them to send me subs because I could go crazy, especially if they call me in the middle of the day and I have to get three or four subs, I'll pull my hair out. So I put it on them. Sometimes I do of course, but, if they give me a couple of weeks notice or so. But if it's within the same week I expect them to get a sub for me. I have my core people and then we have a list of subs that they can call which they've provided over the years. So that works out very nicely. As a matter of fact it happened for this particular gig, we have about three or four subs that are coming in. But they've played with the band before so it's not a problem. And they're very good excellent musicians.

MR: I would imagine you've got to have a bass player who really knows this music.

VR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: Because the first time I tried to at least absorb some of this Latin music and much of it where the bass is anticipating, and it just seemed so incorrect. We're used to jazz, we're used to walking bass, we're hitting the downbeats, even if it's a funky thing usually.

VR: Well it happened yesterday, the young man caught on very quickly, but I had to tell him [scats] and then he went down to [scats] which is good too, that's an older style as I mentioned to him. And that worked out very nicely what he was doing. But yes you have to be very knowledgeable. I have a bass player that played with Tito Puente for many years and he played with Rubén Blades, I don't know if you know that particular name. But he's very experienced in the field for the past fifteen years or so. And then the one I have today — he couldn't make it because he already had a gig. I have Ian Stewart, so I think he's come here he told me, he's from here. He's a young man, early 30s, he's got a lot of experience already. He wrote a book with John Benitez on Latino bass playing. So he's very knowledgeable, so he plays with the band periodically. So yes. Also, the same thing with the piano players, they have to know how to play with the percussion and the rhythm and the bass player. The one that I'm not very good at is the guitar. I have to learn more. Because the guitar is kind of tricky because they have to play with the piano but

not necessarily the same thing so how do you do it without getting in the way. So that's one thing that I haven't looked into you know, that much. I depend on them to sort of do it, if I happen to use a guitar player.

MR: How does your percussion fit into swing music?

VR: It can. I'm sure you're familiar like let's say [scats] instead of playing straight eighths like on the conga [scats] you just swing it [scats]. And that's one way you could get around it. The bongos, instead of going [scats].

MR: Okay.

VR: And that's been done over the years, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Nat King Cole used to have —

VR: Yes, with Candido I believe, right? I'm not sure.

MR: What's that?

VR: I think Candido did some recordings with him. So yeah, that's one way to adapt. I didn't pay attention to that, I thought it was something important. And a gentleman I think wrote a book about it. He did a lot of research and he called me for my input and I really didn't have much input to give him because I had never really thought about it but he did like a whole thing with a discography and it's really interesting. But it's basically based on that [scats], just swinging those eighth notes. And that's what I was afraid of yesterday. Chembo, my conga player, we heard you guys playing from outside and he says, "They're swinging the eighth notes." And I was like really? But then when I got inside it was not being swung.

MR: You know what happened, they listened to a recording.

VR: Okay, yeah. So they were doing it before?

MR: I did not hear them before but I know before you worked on it yesterday they put a recording of it on. Do you write with Finale or anything like that?

VR: I use Finale yes, yes, yes. Some people say Sibelius is better. I don't know.

MR: They do say that but I'm a Finale guy also.

VR: Because I've done it for over twenty years, I'm not going to change now.

MR: Indeed. Do you have physical issues with what you do? I mean so much of it is muscles and not only that, moving equipment. Is it trying on your body?

VR: As I get older, yes. I mean I got up this morning, I got up around 5:30 because I was going to meet the guys for breakfast and then I decided to stay at my hotel and I just did exercises with my hands you know and the pad for about an hour and a half. As I get older if I don't move my hands, right, I get stiff. So yes, I do. As I get older — I gain through experience but I think that happens to everybody. So yes, I have to be on top of it. I can't just lay off the instrument, I have to be moving my hands and my body. It's getting harder and harder to move the drums you know. I started off as a drum set player

and now, with this band I actually was playing drum set in the very beginning and then for some reason I let another drummer play for a while until he left to move on to other things. And I didn't move back to the drum set because I find it easier to move the timbales. If I have to move a whole drum set now it's like — I still do it but it's not like when I was young you know.

MR: And the group tonight does not have a drum set playing.

VR: No drum set, no.

MR: So is there a part in what you do where your percussion-mates that takes the place of like the hi hat? Or is it not that specific?

VR: Yes and no. Because if you look at a typical Latino band like the Puente band the Machito, they never had drummers anyway, drum set players. So everything is taken care of. If you want to equate the hi hat to something it would be the sides of the timbales because it's a metal shell that would take the place of it. Because if I was playing drum set I would simply be imitating something that the timbales is doing, or complementing it. So it's not necessary. That's why I decided not to replace the drummer, except when the drummer left to go on some boat cruise gig you know for the next two years. I tried some other drummers and it was just difficult to find a drummer that was willing to come to rehearsals, do the gigs, you know, which most of the time don't pay that well. And then deal with stylistic differences you know. It's hard to find a good drummer that can do that. And we played for a couple of years and I said you know something? We don't need a drummer. We're self contained with what we do, unless we do like a rap thing, which we're not going to do anyway, or a funk thing that we would need a drummer.

MR: One less person to pay, too.

VR: That's right. One less mouth to feed. Exactly.

MR: How has the work scene changed in New York?

VR: In New York drastically. At least talking for Latin music and Latin jazz. When I first got to New York in 1980 there was a lot of work in everything, like hotels had bands you know, we had the Rainbow Room, and clubs where you could play. You could go with your band and you know you would get gigs and you would make anywhere — they never paid a lot, anywhere from $50 to $100 but a hundred dollars back in 1980 was not bad you know. $50 was like the minimum. I remember playing at Mikell's and I remember playing at Visiones right next to the Blue Note. There was wedding gigs, parties, all of that, most of it has died out to the point that there's only a few clubs where you can actually play and usually it's for the door so it's really — and this is New York City. So it's not, for me it's — in my opinion it's not looking very good you know.

MR: Do you know why?

VR: Some. I first saw it in the mid 80s around ’88, well close to 90. I used to play a lot of cabaret, like I would be house drummer in places where we would back up singers. And the city, I don’t remember who was the mayor, I think it might have been Guiliani, Rudy Guiliani, our friend, who they started to enforce a law where you cannot have a live band within a certain amount of feet from a residential area. So all of a sudden they started enforcing a law where you couldn’t have a band. So what they started to do, they started laying off the musicians and they would call — the singers would put on a show with what they call pista or a soundtrack, you know, the music minus the singer. That’s when I first saw it. And they never quite recovered from that. I guess the club owners realized they could get away with it and that was the beginning of the end.

MR: Yeah, the DJ and live performer they’ve kind of —

VR: Yes. And people seem to respond — talking about DJs, they seem to respond more to DJs than to the band. Every year at Lehman College where I teach we play for a Christmas party, we have the full big band, and some people will dance and will look interested. As soon as we’re off the DJ will come on and it’s like ants coming to the —

MR: I had the same experience. The last wedding I played, yeah.

VR: So I do not understand that. Maybe it’s the MP3 generation, I don’t know. I don’t know what it is.

MR: I think it’s [scats].

VR: I remember one time playing with, it was like top musicians, except for myself. I was the young one. It was Manny Duran who played with the Machito orchestra, Eddie Martinez who played with Chico O’Farrill, everybody Gato Barbieri, Patato on congas. The bass player was Victor Menenguez a veteran from the scene. We were playing. Midway the coordinator stopped us, paid us, sent us home, they put a boom box in the middle of the room and people again just started dancing. So they didn’t even appreciate the Latino jazz that we were playing. It was like we were top musicians but that’s where we’re at or that’s where we’re headed. Hopefully not but I’ve seen it happen.

MR: Let’s suppose you went to a party and someone asks you what you do and, “Well I play a lot of Latin jazz.” And that person said, “What makes Latin jazz different from jazz?”

VR: Okay. We have jazz the way we know it, the swing stuff, the bebop, which I wanted to be a jazz drummer at first before I ever got into the Latin thing. So in college I was into Mel Lewis, you know, Buddy Rich of course, Stan Kenton. I went to North Texas State University. So I was studying and playing in the lab. I’ve always loved straight ahead jazz you know and of course I used to listen to all the bebop stuff, Miles Davis and all that stuff. But then one day somebody in the dorm heard me playing some Mexican music, Perez Prado and he put on “Son Montent Sera.” he took me to his room and he said, “Listen to this.” He put some Ray Barreto like just straight ahead salsa but it just

blew my mind away because of the rhythm. It was so strong. And then I started to hear like the bands of Machito, who did a lot of what we call now Latin jazz for me it's the marriage of both because for instance in straight ahead Latino, like a dance tune, it might have one chord like we did yesterday. It might have a 1-4-5 progression [scats] or a 2-5-1 or a 1-6-2-5. You know, the basic chord structure, and of course jazz — it still has that but it might have so many other chords, especially like a ballad. So it's the marriage of the harmonies of jazz and the Latino rhythm. It's not straight ahead you know, which of course people like Elvin Jones can do a lot. But Latino, we have that strong rhythm, that's what makes it Latino jazz. My band I try my best to keep the tradition. I don't like for it to get too, what's the word, too out there. I keep it pretty much in a box of traditional, but then we have the arrangements on top of it, which are like jazz harmonies. You'll be there tonight, I will see you, and you will hear it. So for me that's Latin jazz. And like the big band I always wanted to have a big band because I saw the connection between Stan Kenton, Woody Herman, and Tito Puente, and Machito. Because they took the same format. You know? They didn't quite have — I think Puente had like four saxophones, maybe two bones, I don't remember exactly, three or four trumpets. Not a full sized big band. I think Machito had like four trumpets, four saxes, no bones many times. But it was still the same format. So I saw the connection between the two, between straight ahead jazz, big band and the Latino stuff. So for me that's Latin jazz.

MR: Okay. Good answer. Your band mates speak of this music with great reverence for its history and lineage and yesterday's lecture-demonstration was a lot about spirituality. But the music exists in the spiritual realm as well as the secular realm. It is — what might happen — I'll rephrase. Would there be something that a person could do with this music that would be irreverent and frowned upon? If you're playing music that's connected with spirituality and deities, can it be abused?

VR: It can be. We've come a long way on that. Back in the — I'll go back to the early 1900s, Fernando Ortiz, I don't know if you know that name, he was a Cuban anthropologist who was actually the first to bring out the batá drumming meaning to the public, because back then it was sort of like secretive, Cascadú spoke about you could be actually punished for playing those drums in public. But it was also in respect to the deities. And even it went on also up to the 80s, when I first came to New York in 1980 I tried to get people to teach me how to play the drums, the batá drums, and people didn't want to do that unless they knew you, you had to sort of hang around with them until you got their confidence and they would start showing you. So the way they got around it, started going back again, I'm sort of jumping around, I believe it was 1936, instead of bringing out the religious drums or sacred drums, the batá drums, they made what we call abaqua they're not sacred. So, because it is believed that the sacred drums has — they do

something to it, I'm not even sure I should say, there's something inside the drum that it called ayan. So you're not supposed to bring those drums out into the open. So if somebody did that, yes, that would be an abuse of that culture, of maybe even the deities you know. So you don't want to do that. Also those drums, when they're used in a religious ceremony they're supposed to be put away at least before dark. So you play from 12 to 6 or whenever and then you put them away. They're never supposed to touch the floor. And I could go on with things, but those drums are not to be played in public. And they cannot be handled by just anyone, you have to go through a ritual where you, and again Cascadú mentioned it yesterday where you become omoayan where you ask the deities whether this person is accepted to do this, and then they give you permission or not give you permission. So that's part of it. So yes, there are certain things. But again, if you're using non-sacred drums you can do just about anything. In my opinion I still respect, like I wouldn't put it in an environment where it might be disrespectful to the culture or the deities. I mean I don't know, I'm not sure how I could put that. Like a rhythm legua if I put it in an environment where it's not — if it's counterproductive I won't do that, just out of respect.

MR: Okay. You think of the, like the Miami Sound Machine or some novelty hits like the Macarena —

VR: You could do it.

MR: It's like it's okay.

VR: Yeah it's okay. As long as it's not disrespecting the culture or the tradition or the drums or the rhythms themselves, in my opinion you can do just about anything. Oh yes, women are not supposed to touch the sacred drums also, there's a whole thing about that. But as they get older now I hear it has to do something with menopause and you know, the period. Because blood is not good when you're around the deities. So supposedly they feed on that. So I shouldn't be talking too much about that.

MR: Well it's part of the culture. And I was sort of thinking after I was learning about this stuff yesterday, that all religions have — they have icons. You know the Catholic religion has its icon, it has symbols, it has physical movements, and the religion that you're talking about has its drums.

VR: Exactly. But as long as you play them like — a student of mine asked me, because he's learning batá , and he comes every Sunday to me where we have the class. He's learning very quickly. He says, "Do I have to be part of the religion? You know. No you don't. You can play as much as you want. Later on when you've reached that stage, you have to make a decision how far you want to take it as far as that spiritual side of it is involved. But it doesn't have to be. You can play the drums as much as you want. A woman can learn as much as she wants. And there's no research on that.

MR: Is it a healthy religion or is it shrinking in numbers?

VR: I think it's growing. It's a very — I'm not Santero by the way, I'm like sort of one-on-one. It's a very open religion. It doesn't reject other religions. It's always been synchronized with the Christian religions. So like I can go to a ceremony and pay my respects there and then I can walk into a Catholic church and it's not a problem you know. So it's very open. And it's based mostly on self-improvement. Like how can you be a better person. And that's what they profess, as well as other religions. But this one in particular, I see that a lot. I'm going to do this for a deity because I want to see how I can improve myself. And that's the whole idea behind it. And hopefully it will stay that way.

MR: All three of you gentlemen seem at ease with others and fairly peaceful. And I'm wondering what makes you angry?

VR: What makes me angry.

MR: It could be a musical thing or perhaps —

VR: For me, disrespect. When somebody talks to me in a certain way and there's no reason for it, that makes me angry. You know like you're very respectful you know. Students can be disrespectful. They don't make me angry but they get annoying, it's like don't do that. When you talk to me at least talk to me — you can disagree with me but don't disrespect me. That's my philosophy with life pretty much. Just treat others the way you expect to be treated, and if they do it most of the time I'll call them out on it, just don't talk to me that way, don't treat me that way and I'll do the same. That's like my prayer for the week. On Mondays I do a certain thing, a little ritual, and I always say, I ask the higher beings, including God, help me — I ask for guidance and I always say, "Help me, guide me in saying the right things and doing the right things so that I can not only help myself and improve myself but help others in the process." And that's what I live by on a weekly basis. I do that prayer at least — on Mondays before I go anywhere.

MR: I think your students are probably lucky that they have you.

VR: Well I hope so.

MR: Are you an optimist about the future of our country?

VR: Yes. Yes I am. Not to get political but the things that are happening right now, in other countries when you have conflicts they assassinate you or they'll kill you. Here it's in check. I think the balances are working for us. It's a struggle but you know I think in the end we're going to come out good. So yes, I am optimistic that things will work out in this world, in this country in particular. Yes I am.

MR: Okay. I'm glad to hear that. Go back to a big rewind. Do you recall a specific moment or moments when you were young where you heard something — you mentioned when you were at North Texas State, but even before that — was there something that you said what is that, I need to do that, or I want to find out more about that?

VR: I remember a recording, which I'm sure you've heard, Don Ellis "Live at the Fillmore East." I remember getting up in the morning because I was in the — what was that music club where you got records in the mail?

MR: Columbia?

VR: Columbia Record Club. So I got my record for the month and I got my Don Ellis. It was like 7:30 in the morning. I put it on — all this drumming and all this odd meters. And I was like whoa my God. And I was like a 15, 16 year old. And that really hit me. And I wore out that album, I loved it. So yeah, that's one of the ones that, it really changed my life because it wanted me to have something and it made me feel good when I heard that album. Yes. And seeing the Stan Kenton band back in 1967 or so, I was only about 11 or 12 back then, and to see these guys playing there, and seeing Kenton doing his thing. That really hit me. So seeing live music. I'm from Corpus Christi so we used to have the Corpus Christi Jazz Festival. It was like in June or July. So seeing these musicians really made a big impression on me and it made me want to play, which is why going back to the MP3 stage where I think a lot of young people are not seeing that type of playing anymore. They don't see bands. And I think it has an effect on how they respond to music. It could be. I'm not sure you know.

MR: Yeah, it's easy to sound like these aren't the good old days. We had the good old days. But I think the process of going to a record store and hearing something on the radio and seeking it out and buying a physical product, at least for our generation, worked for us.

VR: Yes. I remember getting my first teacher had the Buddy Rich Swinging You Big Band, which I'm sure you have. And I ordered it. I had to go to the store and order it because they didn't have it. And then I got the Swinging Big Face?

MR: "Big Swing Face." Yes.

VR: But I had to order it you know. The guy would look it up in this big fat catalogue and get the number and I had to wait a couple of weeks to get it you know. But then you got that record and you cherished it.

MR: Indeed.

VR: And you heard it for the next five years almost every day. So I think those days are gone, because now we've got too much information and you can not even listen to all that information. You don't have enough time.

MR: This is sort of a historical question, I don't know if you'll have an opinion on it. Jelly Roll Morton, you know the early jazz pianist, was quoted when people would say well what is jazz, and he would say it's this and that, but it has to have a Spanish tinge to it. And I always wondered what he meant by that. I wonder if you have an opinion on it. To me when he says "Spanish" I think he means the music comes from south of our border.

VR: There was a lot of, I'm sure you have that book, "The Latin Tinge" who was the author of that? I don't remember but you know what I'm talking about.

MR: Yes.

VR: And it talks a lot about the Caribbean influence. [scats] It has like what they called that cincio rhythm [scats] you could put it in clave. A lot of it has the [scats] that's the cincio. [scat] It's five notes. Cincio means cinco and that music came to New Orleans. And a lot of it came via Mexico, I didn't know that, that there was like a family of teachers that came through New Orleans to teach and they were very influential in the early development of jazz, which I never knew. So I think that might be what he was referring to, I can not be one hundred percent, but that Latino tinge, what this author referred to, that's what he was talking about. There was a guy named Gottschalk.

MR: Yes, Louis Gottschalk.

VR: And he was influenced by that, or he actually went to South America and died or something, if I'm correct. He got sick, but it was that [scats] that type of thing that's prevalent in the early jazz stages. That's my opinion from what I've read and listened to over the years.

MR: Wow. Well I have to get you to your next assignment. But it's really fascinating talking to you and I'm looking forward to your band tonight. Do you write out a set list beforehand of course?

VR: Oh yes, yes, yes, I have a set list which, it's in the book. The book's right in order, everything's all set.

MR: Did you ever have to fire anybody?

VR: Reluctantly, yeah. Most people leave on their own, not because they're mad or anything but they move or whatever. The only time that I let go of a couple of people was on a recording session, they couldn't quite cut it, and it was like keep them and be faithful or look out for my reputation and all my money that I'm spending, which is thousands of dollars. So it was a rough decision but I had to do what I had to do, just to keep the quality of the music up. Also by having good musicians in the band that will attract good musicians. If you have mediocrity on comparison I'm not going to want to play with you. So I try and keep musicianship levels high so that people will want to play with me. So yes, at least two times that I can remember I let people go. I did it as tactfully as I could but you know, it is what it is. That's why bandleaders are not popular. You've got to do what you've got to do sometimes. But I only do it as a last resort. Okay, there was one more, but we had a very bad situation, it was like okay it's time. Because that creates, it's like a cancer. Once it starts with somebody it can spread. That's what somebody told me. I said something — you're right. I've got to make a move here. But only as a last resort. I'm not the firing type.

MR: Okay. Well thank you for your time today. I very much enjoyed it.

VR: Thank you Mr. Rowe?

MR: Monk Rowe. That's right.

VR: Beautiful.

MR: See you tonight.